

Realization through Remembrance: Imam ‘Alī and the Mystical Tradition of Islam

This chapter addresses the meaning of *dhikru’Llāh*, ‘the remembrance of God’, one of the most fundamental principles in Islamic spirituality, doing so by focusing upon the Imam’s sayings—viewed essentially as commentaries on the Qur’ānic notion of *dhikru’Llāh*—and engaging also with relevant doctrinal formulations which have emerged from within the mystical traditions of Islam. At the outset of this book we stated that to speak of Imam ‘Alī is to speak of the quintessential spirituality of the Islamic faith. His influence is to be felt wherever spirituality has flourished in Islam, whether this be in the more clearly defined spiritual disciplines of Sufism and Shi’i ‘Irfān, or in the realms of *futūwwa* (spiritual chivalry), the craft guilds, music, poetry and the arts.¹ His presence, as the ‘gate’ to the city of prophetic wisdom, leaves its mark on all the noblest manifestations of the spirit of Islam. As regards the tradition of Sufism, however, one discerns a particularly organic connection with the Imam. For whether they be Shi’i or Sunni, Arab or Persian, Turk or Malay, Mauritanian or Bosnian, the Sufi orders are united in the figure of ‘Alī b. Abī Ṭālib, as it is he who stands at the summit of all of the chains of affiliation (*salāsila*, sing. *silṣila*) by which the Sufi masters trace their spiritual descent from the Prophet.²

‘Alī’s unifying role is also apparent as regards the most important subdivision within Islam, that between Sunnism and Shi’ism. Apart from the vast ground that is shared between the two traditions in regard to essential beliefs and practices, these two branches of Islam are brought together in a particularly direct and existential manner by their common orientation towards sanctity (*walāya*) and gnosis (*ma’rifa*) as the goal of the religious life. In this connection, Seyyed Hossein Nasr writes: ‘Islamic esotericism or gnosis crystallized into the form of Sufism in the Sunni world, while it poured into the whole structure of Shi’ism, especially during its early period.’³ Thus, the esoteric core of Islam expresses itself in Sunni Sufism and in Shi’ite ‘Irfān with different ‘accents’, taking on different forms and expressions, without this spiritual attunement to the essence of the Islamic message of *tawḥīd* being fundamentally altered. Indeed, according to one of the great figures in whom Shi’ism and Sufism are combined, Sayyid Ḥaydar Āmulī (d. 787/1385), the true Shi’i cannot but be a ‘Sufi’ if he plumbs the mystical depths of the teachings of the Imams; conversely, the Sufi is a Shi’i if he becomes aware that the most important roots of Sufism are the Imams of the Ahl al-Bayt, the first poles (*aqāb*, sing. *quḥb*) of the spiritual tradition through whom the mystical blessings of the Prophet were transmitted in an initiatic context. The differences of outward form as regards the two traditions are melted, for Āmulī, in the fire of *walāya*, sanctity, the true substance and goal of Sufism and Shi’ism alike.⁴ And for both traditions, ‘Alī is the *walī Allāh*, the ‘friend/saint of God’, *par excellence*.

The following reference to ‘Alī by ‘Alī Hujwiri (d. 464/ 1071), author of the first manual of Sufism written in Persian, *Kashf al-malījib*, can be taken as altogether representative of the way in which ‘Alī is viewed within the Sufi tradition:

Among them [i.e. the Sufis] is the son of Muḥammad’s uncle, he who drowned in the ocean of trying affliction, and was consumed in the fire of loving passion, (*ghariq-i baḥr-i balā’ wa ḥariq-i nār-i walā*) the leader of the saints and the pure ones (*muqtada-yi awliyā’ wa’l-ʿaṣfiyā’*). In this Path he holds a place of tremendous honour and elevated degree. He had complete mastery over the precise expression of the principles of the supernal realities, such that Junayd⁵ said of him, ‘Alī is our master as regards principles and affliction (*shaykhunā fi’l-uṣūl wa’l-balā*)’... That is, ‘Alī is the Imam of this Path in respect of both theoretical knowledge and practical application (*andar ʿilm wa mu’āmalat imām-i in ʿariqat*), for the adepts of Sufism call the knowledge of this Path its ‘principles’, while its practice is summed up in the endurance of affliction.⁶

The mention here of the ‘endurance of affliction’ reminds us of the Imam’s reference to the sages as those who ‘befriend that by which the ignorant are estranged’, noted in [Chapter 1](#) above. A possible meaning of this elliptical sentence, as advanced earlier, is that one of the things which the sages befriend and the ignorant flee is prayer, and more specifically, the act of pure concentration on the Absolute, excluding all other thoughts; for this is a kind of death, the ego and all its preoccupations being as it were ‘sacrificed’ before the divine Reality on which concentration is exclusively focused. The remembrance of God, the focus of this essay, can be conceived both as the consummation of this concentration as well as constituting the path leading to the summit of spiritual realization: self-effacement before the sole reality of God.

The corpus of Imam ‘Alī’s teachings elucidates in a remarkable manner the notion, the principle and the practice of the *dhikru’Llāh*, a theme of central importance both in the Qur’ān and in the *Sunna* of the Prophet. The sayings of the Imam constitute a valuable commentary on those verses of the Qur’ān referring to the *dhikr*; and, given the centrality of the *dhikr* within Sufi practice and doctrine, these sayings also help one to appreciate why it is that the Sufis refer to the Imam as the first spiritual ‘Pole’ (*quḥb*) of Sufism after the Prophet himself. The close relationship between remembrance and spiritual realization will also be explored in the light of both the sayings of the Imam and the expositions of representatives of the Sufi tradition, particularly those belonging to the school of Ibn al-‘Arabī, known in the tradition as *al-Shaykh al-akbar*, ‘the greatest Master’, on account of his preponderant influence upon the subsequent expressions of Sufi thought.⁷ These expositions can be seen as doctrinal reverberations of the dense, often elliptical, pronouncements of the Imam. Key aspects of the spirituality of the Islamic tradition are brought into sharp focus by these sayings of the Imam, together with the elaborations of the Sufis, on the meaning and the implications of ‘the remembrance of God’.

First, one must look at what is meant by this term *dhikr* and ask why it is given such prominence in the sphere of Islamic devotional practice. The term is extremely rich and no single word in English can do justice to its polyvalence. It comprises the following lexical meanings: remembrance, recollection, invocation, repetition, incantation, recitation; it can also mean memory, mention, telling, relating (as of a story), praise, glorification, celebration, fame, eminence, honour, exhortation, warning, as well as denoting the Qur’ān itself,⁸ or any book of revelation or religion. But the definition that brings us close to the spiritual principle expressed by the term is that given by al-Rāghib al-Isfahānī in his Qur’ānic dictionary. He writes that *dhikr* is that by means of which ‘man preserves that knowledge (*ma’rifa*) which he has attained, so it is akin to memory (*ḥifẓ*), except that memory is spoken of in respect of its function of acquisition (*iḥrāz*), whereas *dhikr* is spoken of in respect of its function of rendering present (*istihḍār*). *Dhikr* is also used to refer to the presence of a thing in one’s consciousness (lit. ‘heart’) or in one’s speech. Thus, it is said that there are two types of *dhikr*: *dhikr* of the heart and *dhikr* of the tongue, and each comprises two further kinds of *dhikr*: a *dhikr* which follows forgetfulness, and a *dhikr* which does not follow forgetfulness but which, on the contrary, expresses a continuous remembering.⁹

As will be seen later, there is much in this definition of *dhikr* which resonates with the Imam’s perspective. What is to be stressed for now is that when the thing remembered, or ‘rendered present’ to consciousness, is God, the importance of the principle of *dhikru’Llāh* becomes clear. *Dhikru’Llāh* should thus be seen, in the first instance and above all else, as a principle of awareness, an in-depth assimilation of the divine presence; but it must also be seen as an action, a practice or a series of practices,¹⁰ and thus as a spiritual discipline. In other words, *dhikru’Llāh* can be understood both as the end and a means to that end, both spiritual awareness and methodic practice aiming at that awareness. It is in the Sufi tradition that this relationship between the practice of the *dhikr*

and the principle of consciousness intended by the practice is most highly elaborated. That is, the *dhikr* is presented both as a contemplative discipline centring on the methodic invocation or repetition of a Name of God;¹¹ and as the cognitive consequence and mystical fruit of this methodic discipline.

The *dhikr* is thus the spiritual method *par excellence* of the Sufis, a discipline which contributes to the realization or assimilation in depth, within the heart, of that which is present to the mind, thus transforming an abstract, notional comprehension of certain ideas into a concrete perception of spiritual realities.¹² Insofar as *dhikru'llāh* is conceived as the permanent awareness of the divine Reality, it can be presented as the quintessence of religion as such, being that which 'once again binds' (*re-ligare*) the human being to God; and thus as the *raison d'être* of all religious rites and practices. If prayer constitutes the core of religious practice, the *dhikru'llāh* is, as the Qur'ān puts it very simply, *akbar*, that is, 'greater' or 'greatest':¹³ 'Truly, prayer keepeth [one] away from lewdness and iniquity, and the remembrance of God is greater' (29: 45).

Numerous sayings of the Prophet attest to the pre-eminence of the remembrance of God. For example, it is related that the Prophet asked his companions: 'Shall I not tell you about the best and purest of your works for your Lord, and the most exalted of them in your ranks, and the work that is better for you than giving silver and gold, and better for you than encountering your enemy, with you striking their necks and them striking your necks?' Thereupon the people addressed by him said: 'What is that, O emissary of God?' He said, 'The perpetual invocation of God—exalted and glorious (*dhikru'llāh 'azza wa jalla dā'iman*).'¹⁴

Likewise, Imam 'Alī affirms, 'Perpetuate the *dhikr*, for truly it illumines the heart, and it is the most excellent form of worship (*huwa afḡal al- 'ibāda*).'¹⁵ The performance of *dhikr* is given much importance in the Shi'i tradition, which records many sayings of the early Imams on the virtues of invoking the Names of God and various sacred phrases.¹⁶ Indeed Imam Ja'far al-Ṣādiq (d.148/765) described his followers in terms of *dhikr*: 'Our Shi'a are those who, when alone (*idhā khala'i*, invoke/remember God much.'¹⁷ The *khalwa*, the spiritual retreat where one seeks to be 'alone' with God, is referred to as follows by 'Allāma Ṭabāṭabā'i, one of the most important masters of Shi'i gnosis in the 20th century: 'As to the particular spiritual retreat (*khalwat-i khāss*) it is distancing oneself from people ... it is especially required during certain types of verbal invocations (*adhkār-i kalāmiyya*)... and is considered essential by the masters of the path.'¹⁸

As regards the Sufi tradition, the following statement by Shaykh Aḥmad al-'Alawī (d.1934) on the *dhikr*, can be taken as altogether representative:

Remembrance is the mightiest rule of the religion ... The law was not enjoined upon us, neither were the rites of worship ordained but for the sake of establishing the remembrance of God ... In a word, our performance of the rites of worship is considered strong or weak according to the degree of our remembrance while performing them.¹⁹

Al-Ghazālī poses the question as to why the *dhikr* should be the most meritorious practice, when it is so simple to perform, compared to all the other acts of worship which are so difficult. He replies that full verification of the reason for this superiority of the *dhikr* can only be arrived at through the 'science of unveiling' (*ilm al-mukāshafa*). But what can be said, from the viewpoint of the practical religious sciences (*ilm al-mu'āmalā*) is that the most efficacious *dhikr* is that which is perpetually performed with the presence of the heart (*ḥuḍūr al-qalb*). This is the aim of the *dhikr*, and it is this which 'takes precedence over all acts of worship; nay, it is through this that the other acts of worship are dignified; this is the ultimate fruit of the practical acts of worship.'²⁰

One is therefore justified in asserting that the principle of *dhikru'llāh* relates to the highest levels of religious practice, contemplative discipline and spiritual realization—and thus to the very heart of Islamic spirituality. Despite all their variety in time and space, their divergent perspectives and accentuations, the Sufis are unanimous on the centrality of the *dhikru'llāh* to their way. Likewise, as seen above, despite all their differences of name and orientation, schools of thought or modes of practice, the Sufi orders are united in the pivotal figure of Imam 'Alī as the one who connects all the later masters of the spiritual path to the Prophet himself. Now this coincidence between the Imam and the *dhikru'llāh* in the Sufi tradition is far from adventitious. For the Imam's elucidation of the meaning of the *dhikr*, in addition to his actual initiation of disciples into its methodic practice, constitutes a key aspect of his role as spiritual guide, the *walī Allāh*, or the Pole (*quṭb*) of his age; it is thus central to his esoteric function within the spiritual tradition of Islam, in both its Sunni and Shi'i manifestations.

As regards the esoteric function of the Imam, it is true that we have little historically firm information about his initiatic role in this domain—that is, his actual initiation of disciples into the practice of invocation (known in the tradition as *talqin*); just as we have precious little about his own initiation into the esoteric practice by the Prophet. This is hardly surprising, given that the practice is, precisely, esoteric; that is to say, it is not enjoined upon all (the exoteric majority) as an obligatory rite. Instead, within both Sufism and Shi'i 'Irfān, the invocation is bestowed upon those with a particular vocation, to those who have received a 'calling' to practise something in addition to the obligatory rites that are binding upon all.²¹ Nonetheless, one should note that there are historical accounts which provide *prima facie* evidence of the role of the Imam in transmitting the *dhikr*. The individuals described in the earliest sources as being devoted to the *dhikr* as a particular practice were known as close associates, if not disciples, of the Imam.²²

The role of the Imam in this initiatic domain is stressed in the orally transmitted sources of the Sufi way, and it is also expressed in several written sources.²³ These refer to reports of the transmission of the *dhikr* from the Prophet to the Imam and from him to several other disciples who went on to initiate others into what later became called the way of *taṣawwuf*.²⁴

Despite the paucity of historically sound material on the period of the earliest usage and transmission of the *dhikru'llāh*, we do have the extremely important literary data provided by the sayings recorded in the *Nahj al-balāgha* and the *Ghurar al-ḥikam*, as well as in the supplications attributed to the Imam. Taken together, these sayings certainly amount to a homogeneous corpus, a distinct body of doctrine, which furnishes the researcher with a rich source of philosophical reflection, spiritual meditation and metaphysical insight into the nature and meaning of this spiritual practice that occupies so central a place in the mystical tradition of Islam.

The sayings which we shall be examining shed light not only on the meaning of the practice of *dhikr*, but also upon the philosophy or epistemology underlying it; and they give precious allusions to the fruits of its practice, that is, its consummation in spiritual realization. Particular attention will be given to the way in which the Imam's sayings, on one hand, constitute an important source of commentary on the Qur'ānic verses that relate to this theme; and, on the other, present us with a clear foreshadowing of the more elaborate doctrines pertaining to the *dhikr* that one finds in the later Sufi and 'Irfānī traditions. The Imam's sayings in this domain are thus something of a bridge, connecting what came before him, by way of prophetic revelation, to what came after him, in the way of mystical elaboration. The texts and manuals of the mystical tradition seem to be making explicit what was more often than not implicit in the Imam's sayings. In other words, the mystics elaborated on the esoteric truths alluded to by the Imam in sayings that were concise, often paradoxical and elliptical, but always intellectually challenging and spiritually fruitful.²⁵ Reflection upon these sayings—in the context of the Qur'ān and the *Sunna*, which they illuminate, and in view of later Sufi doctrine, which they anticipate—can take one closer to a proper understanding of the role of *dhikru'llāh* in the practical, operative and visionary aspects of Islamic spirituality.